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I MYSELF AM A WOMAN

SELECTED WRITINGS OF DING LING

One of China's greatest women writers

Edited by TANI E. BARLOW
with GARY J. BJORGE

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Introduction by

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Dedicated to the memory of
BENJAMIN B. BJORGE
1974–1981

Yecao

"Yecao," written mid-year in 1929, was a turning point in Ding Ling's fiction because in it she changed the way she represented woman and man and the battle of the sexes. The story still contains earlier themes, for example, women's lust, women's weakness, women's independence, but they are connected here to a very new, important figure who would reappear many times subsequently in Ding Ling's fiction. This figure, the experienced author who has won control over her female feelings and failings, would emerge again in stories like "The County Magistrate's Daughter" (1939) and "When I Was in Xia Village" (1941). Yecao feels "like a woman" inside. She has flights of fantasy and regrets the indiscretions of her past. Yet what Nanxia sees in Yecao is what Sophia so longed for Ling Jishi to see in her: intelligence, strength, integrity.

This movement in Ding Ling's writing significantly changed how she depicted sexual difference in her subsequent work. She allows a common ground to emerge between male and female characters. Yecao and Nanxia share the human qualities of reason and feeling. As the narrator puts it, "human beings [are] intelligent things, but once they [become] caught up in emotions, they [grow] extraordinarily confused." Emotion is not the special essence of women any more than reason animates men.

A clue to why Ding Ling began to unravel the Victorian stereotypes she'd found so persuasive and valuable before, is the idea of work. Yecao may long for erotic abandon, but her vocation forces her to focus on things outside desire, just as her experience gives her the ability to foresee the likely consequences of indulgence. Hers is a qualified renunciation; she seems willing to leave open a time for love sometime in the future. But there is no question that work, the daily use of her will to struggle for clarity, is Yecao's road to self-respect. Perhaps the conviction forming

a core part of Ding Ling's early literary imagination, that women are naturally weak, crippled by emotion, seemed less compelling once she had found this strong self in the work of writing.—TEB

Spring arrived; gentle breezes blew in through the window, bringing with them the fragrance of flowers and damp grass. Birds on boughs exchanged calls and the chalky wings of tiny butterflies brushed lightly against stalks of flowers swaying in the wind. Young men and women were changing into light-colored, new, unlined jackets. Tender cheeks enhanced by a rosy glow, black eyes sparkling; in little groups, here and there on outings, they were drinking in the beauty of the spring day with all the heartfelt happiness of young people. These were fleeting, precious days.

Yecao, a young woman of twenty-four, wearing a gray lined dress appropriate to a middle-aged woman, had shut herself up in a small room alone, worrying over the characters in her novel. She had forgotten spring. In the novel that she was imagining, however, there was a spring day, filled with ecstatic and impassioned love, raging like fire. In her stifling room, she couldn't help but recall the course of her own life. How unbearable, how terrible those already vanished days had been! The intoxications of the past, she seemed to believe, could be recaptured somehow. But as she gazed through the window at the white clouds, she came to understand that for her it was not necessary to have everything she'd previously enjoyed. Jaded by past experiences, even were she to have an impassioned romantic experience again, she would be totally untouched by it. Except when indulging herself with memories of a fantasy of two trembling hearts, she found comfort only in her writing. In her novels, she often alluded to her magnificent lonely heart.

Today she was terribly upset because she had endowed an extremely level-headed and rational woman in her novel with unduly passionate emotions. Also, she had let a slight touch of melancholy slip in. This definitely was not the character she had intended to create, but it was the flaw in women that she was able to understand best.[1] She didn't know what would be better, to tear up the manuscript and start over, or to go on writing, but not sympathize with the woman. She couldn't stop thinking about this perplexing problem, but gradually, she turned her thoughts to the social environment that caused women to overemphasize emotions, then to how pitiable women are. In a moment of self-examination, she began to detest herself. Could she stifle her own emotions? Even though it seemed that she needed nothing other than her writing, still

there were times when, freed from external aggravation and lost in prior joys and happiness, she would think of the past—this was something so painful and so tinged with remorse that she could never bring herself to speak or think of it. She thought of the past with resentment and longing, and then, finally, with indifference.

Unavoidably, these thoughts made her a little sad. She felt that she was a useless person. She could not forget the man who had forsaken her for another woman. But neither could she forget their mutual love. Blessed with the ability to analyze herself, she knew very clearly that even if the man were to abandon the woman he now loved, forsake it all and come back to her, she still would not accept such kindness, nor would she find so-called happiness in it. She already looked upon love as a pitiable and laughable toy.

Her thoughts went back to her novel. As before, all she was able to grasp intellectually was the overall mood of the characters. At first a light, pleasant feeling was sustained; in the end only "uncertainty" remained.

At that point, she didn't know how to go about calming down enough to refocus her attention on the unfinished novel. Just then the door glided open; it was the amah with a letter.[2] Happily she took it, opened it, and read it through. She was reminded of something she'd forgotten.

This is what the letter said:

> I want to see you very much. But I feel too embarrassed. I don't know why you have such an implacable, neglectful attitude toward me. Right now my spirit is exhausted. I have no recourse but to plead with you: if it isn't putting you out, I will be waiting for you at nightfall on the lawn in French Park (I assume you know which lawn I mean). No need to sign my name, that isn't important. Written this very day.

Yecao read it with alarm. She had, of course, already put this out of her mind, yet she felt no need to reveal her position. Even if she had been in love with another man, was she expected to write this man to tell him that they could be ordinary friends? She believed that human beings were intelligent things, but once they became caught up in emotions, they grew extraordinarily confused. Nanxia was a typical example. In his everyday conversations, he could make things clear. But in his recent behavior toward her, as she saw it, he had unavoidably lost touch with his usual understanding.

She was reminded that she hadn't seen him for a couple of days and guessed that he had forgotten all about everything, so what a surprise to get a letter today. Presumably, these last few days had been rough on

him, and his plight saddened her. She decided to go to the appointed meeting place this evening.

After dinner, carrying an old thin coat over her arm, she walked leisurely to the park in a soft breeze. In the tall buildings on both sides of the road, lamplight passing through gauze curtains looked soft and red. On a wall, new growth on sweet-smelling vines made the supple shoots hang down the outside. Raising her head, she sighed with longing. The street was both quiet and clean; only a few sparsely placed electric lights were shining, and shadows of trees were imprinted everywhere along the path. She walked under still leafless trees, and the shade deepened somewhat as she continued along in a lighthearted mood.

Most of the visitors to the park had gone, leaving only a few people clustered by the pond in a grove of trees. In twos and threes they sat knee to knee on the low iron benches, talking in hushed voices. Yecao made her way toward the lawn, following the path by the pond. But as time and again she thought of Nanxia waiting for her, this image merged with that of someone else. It made her feel a little ridiculous. Passing by some large trees, by a flower bed, she came to the outermost lawn. To the left a dark form was silently and rapidly walking toward her. At first she was startled, but then she recognized the hunched-over shoulders, the hands shoved into coat pockets, and the despondent and hesitant manner so characteristic of him.

"Oh, it's you, Nanxia," she said with relief. Nanxia did not answer as he shifted his weight forward.

She noticed immediately how the melancholy eyes shone in the dark as they gazed at her. She couldn't help feeling a little current of fear. She saw that his dirty jacket was open. His necktie too was untied, and an expanse of flesh on his chest was exposed by an unbuttoned shirt. His hair was all mussed; that made her feel all the more uneasy, while at the same time, a sense of loathing rose in her heart, as though she regretted coming. But there was nothing she could do now, so she said with a smile, "We've been having nice weather lately. Have you been going out?"

Nanxia did not answer her, but just walked her over to a place that had a few benches. She sat down, looking very tired.

"My but the park is nice at night," she said. "But I haven't been here for a long time—the last time was with you."

Why should Nanxia have to respond to this? A straightforward young man, full of passion, he found this meaningless talk irritating. He continued looking mutely at Yecao.

Yecao understood why he didn't answer, but she wasn't willing to let the silence last too long. This sort of uneasiness no longer held any fas-

cination for her. She no longer required the sort of situations that at one time she had deemed best for goading people into the experience of immense confusion, excitement, and intoxication. Wanting to avoid all of this, she said, "Nanxia, you haven't said a word. Why? If I've done something to make you unhappy, I'll go. We can get together again when you feel better."

She was just getting up to go when Nanxia's eyes stopped her short. "I haven't said anything," he said in an imploring tone, "because so much of what has been said has oppressed me so cruelly that there's nothing I can say. Please, I beg of you, sit down for a moment and let me think." As Nanxia was speaking, he moved the bench a little closer and reached out to take her hand.

It was so obvious—she knew the role she was playing—that she thought she should leave. She felt that she ought to reject this man. But she also felt great pity for him, and as she grasped his bony hand, her heart was moved in spite of her feelings.

As she looked at him again, the lights along the path illuminated his face: ashen, his eyebrows knotted and his eyes filled with despair. Her gaze moved down to his mouth: lips raised in a grimace and, in the light of the lamps, the suggestion of a moustache. She couldn't help but be reminded of the past. Involuntarily, she squeezed his hand hard. Nanxia turned his head away and quietly sighed.

On a little path in the distance, a couple could be seen embracing, pressed together so tightly they appeared to be a single person.

Again, Yecao began to reflect back on events in the past. She recalled the spring day three years ago when she too was cradled against a man's chest. They would come to the park at nightfall for their outings and wouldn't go home until midnight. She remembered that when she had been in that man's arms, her heart felt as if it would break—such a youthful heart that could be filled with so very, very much happiness. Besides, she had to admit that she also knew how to tease a man to the point of blazing passion and so satisfy his needs. But now it was all over, all of it. She couldn't treat this friend with the same cruelty. She could only sympathize with him, a man who had misplaced his love, one who had chosen the wrong woman.

"I wish you could understand me better," she said to him sincerely. "The way you're acting saddens me."

"Yecao," he finally spoke. The bleakness of his voice made each word bear down heavily on her heart. "I am profoundly miserable, and this misery comes precisely from my understanding of you. I am no longer an adolescent who can innocently, romantically play my role in the script. But I am cursed in that I haven't the strength to suppress my

impulses, either. Still, my desires are not excessive. If only you would say 'I love you' once, that would be enough. But, Yecao, I know you—your heart is harder than other women's, you are unmovable. You love only yourself and your work. Of course, there's nothing wrong with that. You never led me on. Your attitude toward me has been that you will laugh and joke with me, without ever making a point of the fact that you are a woman. But, Yecao, let me put it this way, and hope you don't think I'm too blunt. It's precisely because of your attitude that I honor you, respect you, and love you so much! For some time I have known that I'm wrong, but I can't disentangle myself! Sometimes I think I will simply go crazy, and even though the consequence would be that you'd have nothing more to do with me, I'd be willing. But I don't have the courage. Actually, I've often felt like a madman, only I've always managed to suppress it. Ah! What should I do?"

Forceful as the words were, Yecao reacted as a woman whose heart was indeed harder than other women's. For besides sympathizing with him, she also saw him as being slightly ridiculous. She wondered what good anything she said would do. If you feel so miserable and can't stand it, then you don't have to love me, especially since you know that my heart is immovable. Or, though misery is bitter, it can also be sweet; you can go on loving me. I do not have the right to interfere or forbid you to love me. So if you feel that you absolutely must go mad, take it out on me to satisfy yourself, then there is nothing more I can do about it. Since you insist on driving yourself so hard, go right ahead. Quite simply, of what use are words? Why ask me? Can I command you? Ai, you're no child! But she kept these thoughts to herself, showing him only the veneer of a smile as she took his hand once more and said earnestly, "I can't give you any comfort. I can only hope you will not lose sight of what is more important to you. As for me, I've put it all behind me. And it's not that I don't feel bad about that—there's an emptiness inside me—but I no longer have any desire for love."

Nanxia was silent again. Finally, he poured out his heart to her, disclosing his first impressions of her. He was so worked up that at times he appeared on the verge of tears.

The leaves of the white poplars rippled, the wind was cool; Yecao felt cold. She started to put on her coat, and Nanxia innocently helped her into it. Fearful that she might be cold, he suggested that they take a stroll. That sounded like a good idea to her, so she got up, and hand in hand they walked toward a darker place.

Tender new grass felt soft beneath their feet, and long willow branches were swaying in the dim lamplight. The night was quiet, not a sound anywhere. A half-moon had risen, shedding weak light. Yecao saw that

her shadow and his slept with each other on the ground ahead of them as they walked along.

Appearing a little happier, he expressed his feelings for her again. He did not lie to her. Not at all. When they were together, they talked openly and honestly about everything, and he didn't seize upon her ambitions. But as soon as he left her, he was in agony; it seemed he'd rather die than fail to win her love. He began to feel sorry for himself. Again he asked her if she'd grown tired of him.

She shook her head and said softly, "No."

He smiled childishly at her, "Then I'll never leave you. I'll move next door to you."

"What if I've grown tired of you by then?"

"As long as you approve now, everything will be all right."

They walked up to a path. The dense trees in the darkness on both sides blocked the light from the lamps outside. Blown by the wind, the leaves of the willows and the palms rustled incessantly; they were so dense that even the stars were blacked from view. Because the path was narrow and dark, the two of them walked closely together, each feeling the warmth of the other's body. Nanxia put his arm around her waist. His heart pounding, he wanted nothing more than to take her into his arms and madly kiss her face and body, but he didn't dare. He could only test her out by saying, "Yecao! You know I love you. Aren't you afraid to walk with me alone here?"

The setting made her feel a little uncomfortable, but she wasn't the least bit afraid of him. On the contrary, she wished that he would let himself go so she would once again enjoy that intoxicated feeling.

"I'm not afraid," she said sadly (only she knew she was sad). "I'm not afraid, because I trust you."

Words formed in his mind: he wanted to ask if she would let him say "my love" to her. But before he could say anything, the path ended in a spot of bright illumination. They released each others' hands unaware they'd done so.

When they came to the pond, the clear flowing spring water gurgled lightly, and the moon on the surface of the water rose and fell like waves. Roses alongside the bridge gave off breaths of sweet-smelling fragrance. Yecao reflected on what had just happened, and felt that it was in terrible taste. She looked at Nanxia coldly.

A fish splashed in the pond, sending spray everywhere. There were already tiny white buds on the lotus pads.

As they sat beside the pond, she was preoccupied with various ways of describing a night scene. She was thinking how a certain scene would be

perceived by one person and how it would be changed when perceived by another.

But Nanxia looked at her happily. He was wishing that every night could be like this one.

She wanted to go back. She wasn't at all reluctant about leaving. As for him, he still hadn't heeded the look in her eye that proved he'd made no headway. Feeling much happier than when he came, he just asked her if they could meet again the next night and if he could see her home tonight.

She turned him down. She still had work to do and was afraid that he would disturb her. On the way home she sang, apparently very happily, her newly composed, well-turned phrases.

Translated by Charlotte Calhoun